when Indians were subordinate subjects of a faraway sovereign. Despite being a developing country with limited economic and military potential at Independence in 1947, Indian leaders projected themselves as the inheritors of a great civilization and the trailblazers of a future big power. In his presidential address to the parliament in 1999, then president K.R. Narayanan restated something that has been said and resaid several times since the departure of the British. India, he announced, will secure 'a place, role, and position in the global arena, commensurate with its size and importance'.[14]

Under the influence of the founding fathers like Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru, the average Indian has also believed that India was special, is special and will remain special. This 'Indian exceptionalism' – the term used by several public figures – rested on the faith that there was something unique about India, which enabled it to gain independence without violence, revolution or war. Other aspects of the same conviction are that India is special because it is the land of Gandhi and Nehru or that India's ability to subsume various cultures under the rubric of Indian tolerance makes it unique. Indian discourse often speaks of an 'Indian character' that will overcome odds and circumvent difficulties. In the words of a former Indian president, 'The vision of a mighty India will be realized only in the actual lives of men and women who have strength of character.'[15]

'India stands tall as a nation because we are seen as a liberal and plural democracy, which has faced and overcome tremendous odds,' declared the current president, Pranab Mukherjee, in his presidential address of February 2013. According to him, 'The world recognizes India's demonstrable democratic and secular practices as a major achievement. While we should rejoice in the benefits that our plurality brings, the challenge is to relentlessly pursue our efforts to accelerate economic growth and widen opportunities within our democratic framework. It is only if we constantly